

INTRODUCTION

Picture the scene: a huge stadium in ancient Rome is packed with a noisy, excited crowd. They are here to watch gladiators fight to the death. Suddenly, the spectators fall silent as a fighter falls to the ground wounded. Then they start to shout in Latin "*Iugula!*" It means "Kill him!"

It's hard to imagine that anything so horrible, so bloodthirsty, could ever have happened. But to the Romans, the spectacle of highly trained fighters attacking each other with swords, daggers, lances, tridents, and nets was simply great entertainment!

Although gladiators are long gone, the fascination with these Roman fighters is as strong as ever. Today, crowds still like to watch them perform—not in blood-soaked stadiums,

but in plush movie theaters, where actors play the part of Roman fighters. As we watch the latest blockbuster film, packed with



THIS CARVING OF TWO WOMEN FIGHTING SHOWS THAT WOMEN, AS WELL AS MEN, FOUGHT AS GLADIATORS.